

Week 1: What Is the Bible?

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

The Bible has a long, layered history — tonight we'll look at what it actually is and where it came from.

1. When you hear the word "Bible," what comes to mind first — a single book, a rulebook, a library, a story? Where do you think that picture came from?
2. **Read 2 Timothy 3:15-17.** What does Paul call Scripture, and what does he say it's useful for? His word for "God-breathed" is the Greek *theopneustos* — what does it mean for something written by human authors, shaped by their own time and place, to also be described this way?
3. The Old and New Testaments were written by dozens of authors across more than a thousand years, in different languages, under very different circumstances. Why do you think God chose to reveal himself this way, rather than through one text handed down all at once?
4. **Read Hebrews 4:12.** What does this verse say God's word actually does? The author calls it "living and active" rather than just "true and reliable" — is that how you typically experience the Bible when you open it, or does it feel more like a historical document or a moral rulebook? What would need to change for "living and active" to be your honest, default expectation?
5. **Read Luke 24:13-27.** What does Jesus do for the two disciples on the road, and where does he start explaining himself from, according to verse 27? What does that tell you about how Jesus himself understood and read the Old Testament?
6. The Bible mixes narrative, poetry, law, letters, and wisdom writing. How do you think these different kinds of writing work together to tell one story, instead of just being a grab-bag of unrelated material?
7. Christian traditions (Protestant, Catholic, Orthodox) don't all agree on the exact list of books in the Bible. Does that surprise or unsettle you? Does it change how much confidence you place in Scripture — why or why not?

8. BibleProject argues the Bible tells one continuous story that leads to Jesus. Does that story continue today, in the church and in your own life? If so, how do you see yourself as part of it?
9. What's one assumption about the Bible — how it was written, what it's for, how it should be read — that you're willing to have challenged over these 19 weeks?
10. As you start this study, what's one thing you're hoping to walk away with?